



Foundations of Āyurveda

Course Overview Sheet



Course Information

Course Code	IK 702 (Institute Elective)
Semester	Autumn 2026
Credits	6
Classroom	LT 206
Lecture Hours	Wed, Fri 9:30 – 10:55AM

Instructor Information

Instructor	Prof. Ashish Karn
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Office Hours	Mon–Thu, 4–5 PM

Course Description

What is health?

Why do we fall ill?

Can disease truly be prevented?

Every civilization has grappled with these questions. Āyurveda represents one of humanity's oldest, most systematic, and intellectually sophisticated attempts to answer them. Indeed, it may be one of the oldest systems biology frameworks ever developed—an integrated way of understanding the human organism in which the body, mind, environment, diet, lifestyle, and the rhythms of nature are viewed not as isolated components, but as an interconnected whole.

This course is not a manual of home remedies, nor is it an invitation to accept traditional knowledge uncritically. Rather, it is an opportunity to study Āyurveda as an intellectual tradition—one that developed its own philosophy of biology, physiology, diagnosis, prevention, and therapeutics centuries before the emergence of modern biomedical science. Along the way, we shall ask difficult questions, compare different ways of understanding the human organism, and examine where ancient insights continue to provoke contemporary scientific thought.

Whether you eventually agree with every Āyurvedic concept is beside the point. By the end of this course, you should be able to appreciate Āyurveda not merely as a traditional medical system, but as a sophisticated body of knowledge worthy of careful, critical, and intellectually honest study.

Perhaps more importantly, you may begin to look at your own body - and your own health - with questions you had never thought to ask. The greatest outcome of this course would not be that you remember all the verses of Āyurveda - it would be that Āyurveda changes the way you observe yourself!

Course Objectives

- Develop a systems-level understanding of health and disease through the foundational principles of Āyurveda.
- Critically examine Āyurvedic concepts in the light of history, philosophy, and contemporary scientific thought.
- Relate Āyurvedic principles to everyday life for informed choices concerning health and well-being.
- Develop the intellectual foundation to engage with the classical Āyurvedic texts and pursue further study or research in Āyurveda.

Prerequisites

Officially: None.

Unofficially: An open mind, intellectual curiosity, and a willingness to occasionally question what you thought you knew about health. An interest in India's knowledge traditions will be an added advantage.

Course Contents & Pedagogy

- **Lectures and Pre-Lecture Readings:** The course unfolds through two parallel journeys. The lectures systematically introduce the foundations of Āyurveda, while the daily essays explore broader questions concerning medicine, health, society, and civilization. Although they occasionally intersect, they are intended to encourage independent reflection. The detailed lecture schedule, weekly plan, and pre-lecture readings will be available on Moodle.
- **Reflection Exercises:** Each lecture concludes with a brief written reflection. These reflections are an important part of the learning process and should be completed sincerely.
- **Experiential Learning:** The course includes a mandatory visit to a local Ayurvedic herbal garden to provide first-hand exposure to Ayurvedic herbology and medicinal plants.

Evaluation Scheme

Component	Weight
Quizzes/Assignments	20%
Mid-semester	30%
End-semester	50%
Bonus (upto)	10%

- * Up to five quizzes/ assignments may be conducted. The best four scores will count.
- * Regular attendance and meaningful class participation may earn bonus marks.
- * Audit students must maintain at least **75% attendance** and comply with all course policies.

Course Policies

Attendance: Students are expected to maintain a minimum attendance of **70%** to avoid the award of a DX grade, in accordance with Institute regulations.

Punctuality & Classroom Conduct: Punctuality reflects professionalism and respect for others' time. A delay of up to 5–10 minutes for genuine reasons is acceptable. Students arriving later should seek the instructor's permission before entering the classroom. The course emphasizes active discussion and student engagement. The classes will be interactive. Feel free to participate. Meaningful participation may earn a bonus of up to **10%** on your total score.

Use of Mobile Phones: The use of mobile phones is **strictly prohibited** during lectures. They should be switched off or kept in silent mode and out of sight (to avoid temptation). Unauthorized use will be regarded as disruptive behavior and may attract an academic penalty.

Academic Integrity: Students are expected to uphold the highest standards of academic integrity. In addition to the course policies outlined above, they are required to comply with the relevant IIT Bombay regulations, such as the *Undergraduate/Postgraduate Rule Book* and the *Guidelines on Academic Malpractices*.

Feedback. Students are encouraged to participate sincerely in the brief end-of-class reflection exercises in addition to the Institute's formal feedback process. Academic concerns may be discussed with me by email/phone or during office hours. I will do my best to help you out!

Reading Materials

Primary Texts

Caraka Saṃhitā, *Suśruta Saṃhitā*, *Aṣṭāṅga Hṛdayam*, and *Bhāvaprakāśa*.

Textbook

Vasant D. Lad (2002), *Textbook of Āyurveda*, Volumes I–III, Āyurvedic Press.

References

Frawley & Ranade (2017), *Āyurveda Nature's Medicine*, MLBD.

Moodle

Weekly readings and supplementary resources (Pre-Lecture readings).